Teaching a Neural Network the Glow of the Solar System

A geometrically constrained model of zodiacal light for NASA's SPHEREx mission

Mark Burch and Andrew Saydjari
Astronomy Department, New Mexico State University, Las Cruces, NM

A geometrically constrained neural network learns the zodiacal light from viewing geometry alone, reaching ~0.02% median error on months it never saw.

Background

- **SPHEREx:** NASA space telescope (launched March 2025) mapping the **entire sky in infrared** (0.75–5 μm)
- **Science:** how the universe began, how galaxies formed, where water and other ingredients for life are found

Zodiacal light

- Sunlight scattered by dust from comets and asteroids, plus the dust's heat glow (Fig. 1)
- Bright enough to be confused with faint light from distant galaxies
- Changes with look direction and Earth's place in orbit → **must be modeled and removed**

The Kelsall model

- Standard dust model from NASA's COBE (Fig. 2); **ZodiPy** computes what SPHEREx would see from it

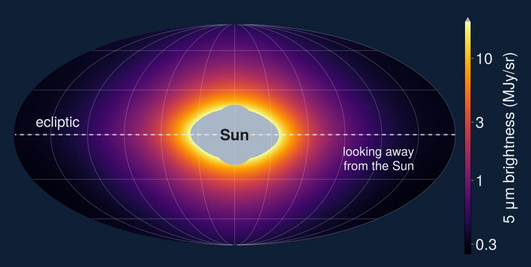


Figure 1. The whole sky at 5 μm from SPHEREx (ZodiPy): brightest toward the Sun and along the plane of the planets. Grey: too close to the Sun to observe.

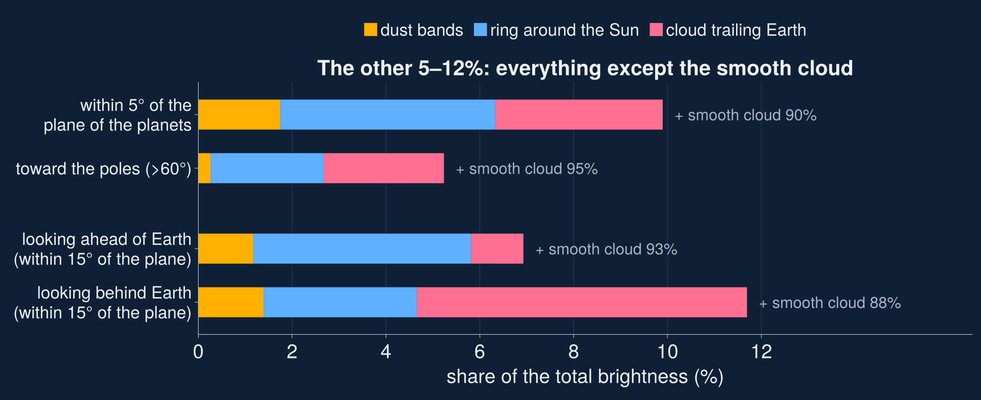


Figure 2. What makes up the zodiacal light SPHEREx sees (Kelsall model): a smooth cloud (88–95%) plus dust bands, a ring around the Sun, and a cloud trailing Earth, strongest when looking behind Earth.

The problem

- Zodiacal light must be removed from every SPHEREx image, but models like Kelsall's were fit to older data and leave errors behind

Research objective

- A **geometrically constrained** neural network that learns zodiacal light from SPHEREx data and **outperforms the Kelsall model**. First step: ZodiPy's simulated sky

Methods

A geometrically constrained model

- No dates or sky-map positions: only **9 numbers describing the viewing geometry** (Fig. 3)
- It must learn how brightness depends on geometry, as the physics does, not memorize when and where SPHEREx looked

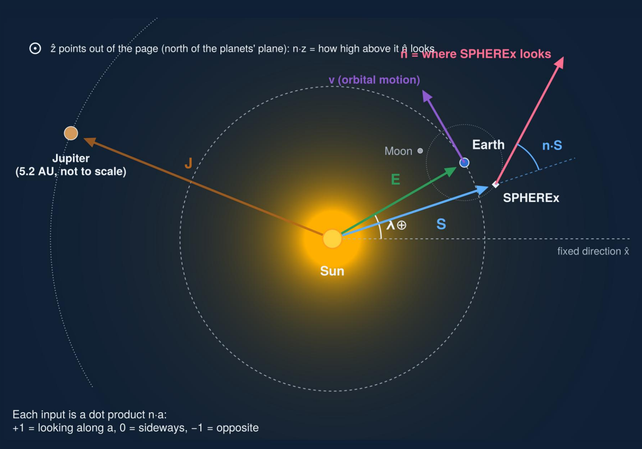


Figure 3. The geometry the network sees (top view, not to scale): n = where SPHEREx looks; S, E = Sun → SPHEREx, Earth; v = orbital motion; λ⊕ = Earth's angle around its orbit. Jupiter and the Moon: context only.

The 9 inputs

n·S, n·E	toward or away from the Sun (seen from SPHEREx and from Earth)
n·z	how far above or below the plane of the planets
n·vS, n·vE	ahead of or behind the orbital motion (SPHEREx, Earth)
n·x⊕, n·y⊕	look direction in a frame that turns with Earth (x⊕ = Sun → Earth)
sin λ⊕, cos λ⊕	Earth's position in its orbit: the time of year

Training and testing

- 423,607 simulated pointings (140 days, 5 μm); five small networks (Flux.jl), averaged
- Tested on whole months and sky regions they never saw
- **Lesson:** adding the time of year (sin λ⊕, cos λ⊕) cut the errors ~40–65×

Results

0.018% median error on months withheld from training

97.5% of pointings within 0.1% of ZodiPy

≤0.03% median error for every choice of withheld months

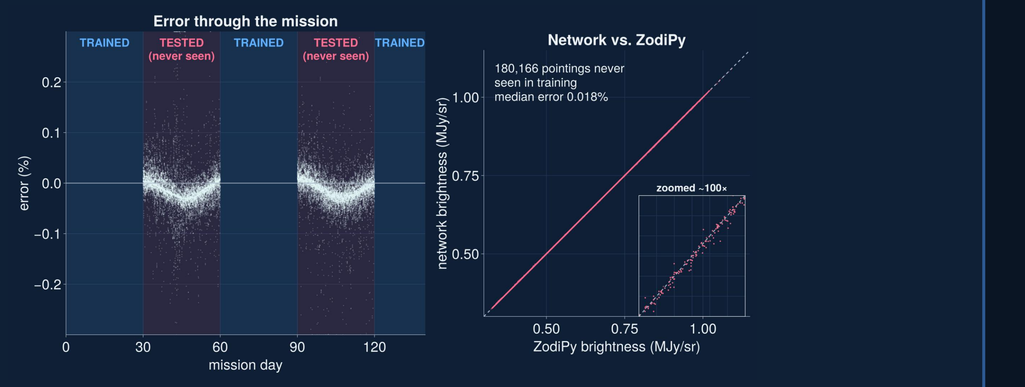


Figure 4. Network vs. ZodiPy on the two 30-day blocks never used in training (days 30–60, 90–120; 180,166 pointings). Left: error through the mission; right: every pointing falls on the 1:1 line.

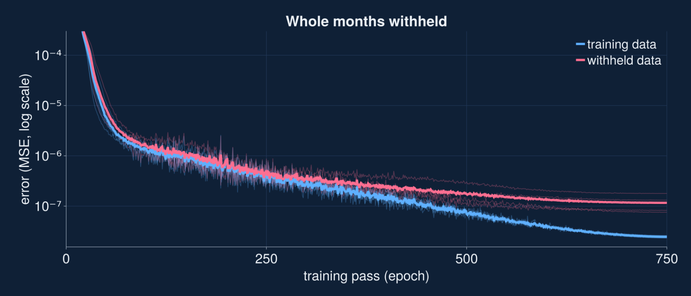


Figure 5. Error during training: 5 networks (thin), average (thick). The error on withheld months levels off and never rises: no overfitting.

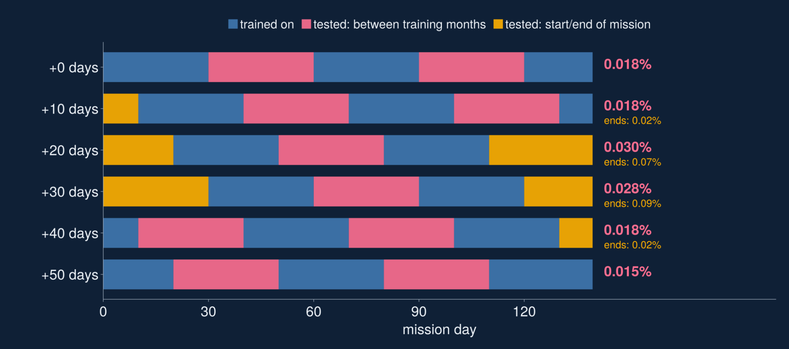


Figure 6. Six versions of the test, sliding the withheld months 10 days at a time: all reach 0.015–0.03% (red). Predicting past the start/end of the data (orange) is harder: fine for ~10 days, then errors grow.

- **Largest errors** along the plane of the planets, where the dust bands are (0.08%); **smallest** toward the poles (0.013%; Fig. 7)

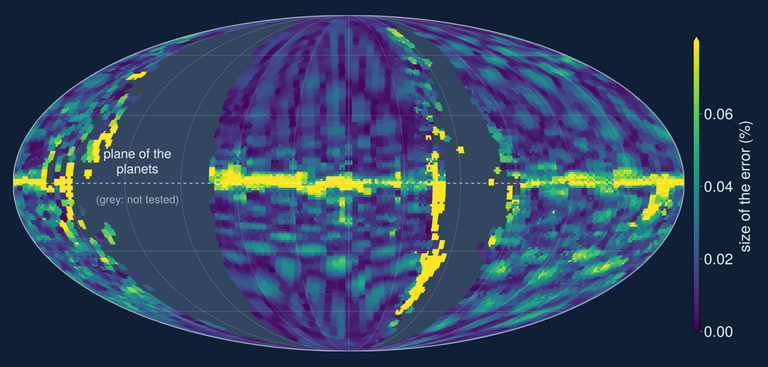


Figure 7. Error on pointings the network never saw, across the whole sky. Each pointing is drawn 3.5° wide, about SPHEREx's view. Grey: not tested.

Next Steps

✓ DONE Validate	Learn ZodiPy's simulated sky from geometry alone; test on unseen months and sky regions
IN PROGRESS Refine	Longer training; all SPHEREx wavelengths (a first 1.25–5 μm version: ~0.1% error)
NEXT Scale up	Move training to a computing cluster
NEXT Real data	Train on real SPHEREx images and compare with the Kelsall model

All results so far are preliminary and use simulated data.

Acknowledgements

This research is supported by a URS grant at New Mexico State University, funded by the National Science Foundation (NSF). Thank you to Dr. Andrew Saydjari for mentorship, and to the developers of ZodiPy and Flux.jl.

References

Kelsall, T., et al. 1998, ApJ, 508, 44 (COBE/DIRBE zodiacal-light model)

San, M., et al. 2022, JOSS, 7, 4602 (ZodiPy)

Doré, O., et al. 2014, arXiv:1412.4872 (SPHEREx)

Innes, M. 2018, JOSS, 3, 602 (Flux.jl)